A vexed relationship with the media is common to all the political contenders described in this chapter. Kejriwal had realized, to his cost, that a movement which had received oxygen in television studios could just as easily be snuffed out by a hostile camera. Mamata and the Bengali media are often locked in bitter conflict. Jayalalithaa has almost stopped giving interviews and only issues the occasional press statement or sound bite. Mayawati treats the media with similar contempt, her press conferences totally scripted, with no questions being allowed. Pawar after his throat surgery is barely audible and, quite simply, un-telegenic. Naveen, too, prefers to keep the media at bay and has perfected the art of monosyllabic responses to any tough questions.

The two top contestants for prime minister were also a study in contrast. Rahul Gandhi still seemed hesitant to open himself to media scrutiny. In comparison, Narendra Modi was preparing to launch the biggest ever media blitz in the history of Indian elections. The divergence was glaring, and in the final analysis, would prove decisive.